Tipu took great exception to what he regarded as the ‘obscene practices’ of the Nairs, whose sexual mores he considered to be ‘more shameless than the beasts of the field’. In 1788 he issued a proclamation ordering the Nairs to forsake their sinful practices, with the threat that he would ‘honour the whole of you with Islam’ if they failed to obey him. The Nairs’ response was predictable, provoking Tipu to issue an order to his army commanders that became known as ‘The Order of Extermination of the Nayars’. Soon he was able to write that he had achieved a great victory in Malabar and that over four hundred thousand Hindus had been converted to Islam – although, as always, we should deduct at least one zero, and possibly two. However, Tipu’s triumph was short-lived. His attack on Travancore brought in the armies of the EICo in alliance with the Nizam of Hyderabad. Tipu was forced to sue for peace and the outcome was that the districts of North Malabar, Salem, Bellary and Anantapur were all ceded to the EICo’s Madras Presidency.

To the British public Tipu Sahib was now represented as the epitome of the oriental despot, a bogey-man whose hatred of the British placed him on a par with Napoleon and made him just as dangerous. But what particularly caught the public imagination was Tipu’s obsession with tigers. By ancient custom Indian rulers had always identified themselves with lions as symbols of royalty, but for Tipu it was the Bengal tiger. According to one of his British opponents on the battlefield, ‘He had adopted as his emblem of state, and as a species of armorial bearing the figure of the royal tiger, whose head and stripes constituted the chief ornament of his throne and of almost every article which belonged to him.’ So Tipu’s banners bore Persian characters shaped into tiger masks, his throne included a number of golden tiger heads, his weapons and possessions carried tiger motifs and stylised tiger stripes, and his soldiers wore tiger liveries. Among the collection of